gaseous exchange, transpiration and most of the metabolic reactions of the plant. The lamina is traversed by the midrib from which arise numerous lateral veins and thin veinlets. The lamina shows great variations in its shape, margin, surface, texture, colour, venation and incision.

Stipules

In most of the dicotyledonous plants, the leaf base bears one or two lateral appendages called the **stipules**. Leaves with stipules are called **stipulate**. The leaves without stipules are called **exstipulate or estipulate**. The stipules are commonly found in dicotyledons. In some grasses (Monocots) an additional out growth is present between leaf base and lamina. It is called **Ligule.** Sometimes, small stipule like outgrowths are found at the base of leaflets of a compound leaf. They are called **stipels.** The main function of the stipule is to protect the leaf in the bud condition.

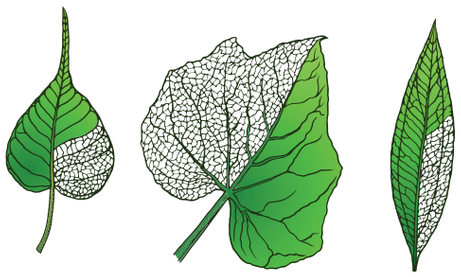
3.7.2 Venation

The arrangement of veins and veinlets on the leaf blade or lamina is called **venation.** Internally, the vein contains vascular tissues. Conventionally venation is classified into two types namely, Reticulate venation and Parallel venation.

I. Reticulate venation

In this type of venation leaf contain a prominent midrib from which several secondary veins arise that branch and anastomose like a network. This type of venation is common in all dicot leaves. It is of two types.

1. **Pinnately reticulate venation (unicostate):** In this type of venation there is only one midrib in the centre which forms many lateral branches to form a network. Example: *Mangifera indica.*
2. **Palmately reticulate venation (multicostate):** In this type of venation there are two or more principal veins arising from a single point and they proceed outwards or upwards. The two types of palmate reticulate venation are



(a) *Ficus* **(b)** *Cucurbita* **(c)** *Cinnamomum*

Figure 3.12: Types of reticulate venation
(a) Pinnately reticulate
(b) Palmately reticulate (Divergent)
(c) Palmately reticulate (Convergent)

   i. **Divergent type:** When all principal veins originate from the base and diverge from one another towards the margin of the leaf as in *Carica papaya*.
   ii. **Convergent:** When the veins converge to the apex of the leaf, as in *Zizyphus* (Indian plum), *Cinnamomum* (bay leaf).

II. Parallel venation

In this type of venation Veins run parallel and do not form a prominent reticulum. It is a characteristic feature of monocot leaves. It is classified into two sub types.

1. Pinnately Parallel Venation (Unicostate)

There is a prominent midrib in the center, from which arise many veins perpendicularly and run parallel to each other. Example: *Musa*, Zinger.

2. Palmate Parallel Venation (Multicostate)

In this type several veins arise from the tip of the petiole and they all run parallel to each other and unite at the apex. It is of two sub types.

i. **Divergent type:** All principal veins originate from the leaf base and diverge towards the margin. *Borassus flabellifer*
ii. **Convergent type:** All principal veins run parallel to each other from the base of the lamina and join at the apex as in Bamboo, rice, water hyacinth.

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